

Lab: Pulling Through, Letting Go

Materials Exploration — Action

Objective

Investigate how your hands act on different yarns by comparing tension, feeding technique, and stitch formation across materials. You will develop awareness of your action policies and how they adapt to different fibers.

Materials Needed

- 3 yarns of different character (e.g., grippy cotton, slippery silk or bamboo, springy wool)
- A crochet hook appropriate for each yarn
- A tension gauge or ruler
- A notebook for observations
- A timer

Part 1: Tension Mapping (20 minutes)

1. Crochet a 15-stitch, 10-row swatch with each of your three yarns, using the same hook and your natural tension.
2. Measure the width and height of each swatch.
3. Rate the tension experience for each yarn:
4. How much did you have to grip? (1-5, light to firm)
5. Did the yarn slip or grab?
6. How consistent was your tension across the swatch?

Yarn	Grip (1-5)	Slip/Grab	Width	Height	Consistency

Reflection: Your hands automatically adjusted tension for each material. The grip rating is a measure of your action policy for that yarn.

Part 2: Feeding Technique Awareness (15 minutes)

1. Observe how you naturally feed each yarn through your fingers. Draw or describe the yarn path.
2. Try an alternative feeding method (if you wrap around the pinky, try threading between fingers instead).
3. Crochet 5 rows with the alternative method. Rate:
4. Comfort (1-5)
5. Control (1-5)
6. Tension consistency (1-5)

Reflection: Each feeding method is a different action policy. Which gives you the best control? Did the alternative method feel awkward — and if so, how quickly did it start to improve?

Part 3: The Action of Switching (15 minutes)

1. Crochet 5 rows with Yarn A.
2. Without pausing, switch to Yarn B and crochet 5 rows.
3. Switch back to Yarn A for 5 rows.
4. Observe:
5. How many stitches did it take for your hands to recalibrate after each switch?
6. Was the transition from A to B different from B to A?
7. Can you see the switch point in the fabric (a change in gauge)?

Reflection: The transition zone is where your action policy is updating. With practice, the zone gets smaller.

Part 4: Conscious Tension Override (10 minutes)

1. Crochet 5 rows at your natural tension.
2. Now consciously try to crochet 5 rows more loosely than your natural tendency.

3. Then 5 rows more tightly.
4. Measure all three sections. How much did gauge change?
5. How did it feel to override your automatic tension?

Reflection: Your natural tension is your default action policy. Overriding it requires conscious effort — moving from automatic to controlled processing.

Discussion Questions

1. Which yarn required the most active adjustment from your hands? Which was most cooperative?
2. Were you aware of your feeding technique before this lab? How much of your action policy operates below conscious awareness?
3. How did the conscious tension override feel compared to your natural tension? Which produced better fabric?

Reflection

Write a short paragraph about action in crochet. How much of what your hands do is automatic? How does the yarn influence your actions? What did this lab teach you about the active, adaptive nature of every stitch?